

The Unfortunates: Game Development Project Report

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Abstract

In this project a story driven and narrative heavy game was created through iterative development with weekly sprint planning. Using *brainwriting* as an ideation method a concept containing cozy gameplay, a dystopian story and a atmospheric and contrasting art-style was decided. The core game mechanics comprised a dialogue system with multiple choices, a 2D platformer movement system, and an interaction system. The game is set in an interpretation of purgatory, where the story is told through dialogue with new arriving spirits to the branch of the Unfortunates. It is a philosophical experience where choices feel big but end up not mattering. Feedback from playtesting was integral to informing design decisions and ensuring that the game satisfies usability concerns and user needs. Later stages of development focused on breaking patterns by adding novel events and making the game feel refined by adding e.g.: animations, sound effects and ethereal movement. The final evaluation showed a high rating for immersion, with comments for improvement mostly outside of the project scope. The game was described as being *narrative driven*, *cozy*, *dark*, *mysterious*, and *dystopian*, and induced desired feelings of *sadness*, *intrigue*, *curiosity*, *irritation/annoyance*, *empathy/helpfulness*. Many users described the game as a "philosophical experience". Considering the feedback from the final evaluation, we believe that *The Unfortunates* succeeded with completing the project goal.

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1 Introduction

In our project we have made a narrative focused adventure game called *The Unfortunates* that was made adhering to the theme of *Cozy Dystopia* by providing a relaxed gameplay experience with a gloomy existentialistic undertone. In this report we will cover how we generated our idea by analyzing the theme, target audience and previous games of this type, and what various methodology we used to make it a reality. We will dive deep into how we designed our game, from the basic mechanics to the art and narrative, and go through the changes to development prioritization from the prototype to the finished product. Importantly, we will touch heavily on the players' experience playing our game that occurred with the initial play testings which inspired various changes, and later the final exposition showcase that gave us feedback about the whole experience. Finally, we will present and discuss the results from the playtesting as well as how the feedback was used to make the game a success.

2 Theme: Cozy dystopia

With a theme as contradictory as *Cozy dystopia*, it was decided to split the theme between gameplay and story. This allowed us to set our *game pillars* that we took into consideration throughout development, with the pillars being: **Cozy gameplay** and **dystopian story**. These pillars were joined through the art style.

Spiritfarer by Thunder Lotus Games [3] was one of our main sources of inspiration because of how well it combines cozy gameplay with the somber story of having to say goodbye to loved ones. Therefore, several elements of the game were incorporated into *The Unfortunates*, with one of them being quite simple 2D platforming with no punishment for failure. This allows the player to easily traverse the carefully designed world, letting them focus on the stories of the NPCs.

Another source of inspiration was *Disco Elysium* by ZA/UM [13] because of the great dialogues, dialogue system and dystopian setting. Using a dialogue system inspired by *Disco Elysium* allowed us to effectively convey the NPCs' stories and personalities.

2.1 Target audience

The Unfortunates is a game for fans of story focused, narrative driven games with a philosophical theme (e.g. *Spiritfarer* and *Disco Elysium*). Prior platforming experience is not essential but could make the game more approachable.

2.2 Goal

The goal for this project was to make a game on the theme *Cozy dystopia*. The game should be small in scope so that it, in the limited time of the project, could be polished enough to be considered a full, finished game that gives players a thought-provoking experience.

3 Methodology

Our development process was based on best practices in software and game development, with an focus on an agile, iterative workflow and structured ideation [6]. This chapter describes our methodology during both the ideation and development phases, along with how the scope evolved throughout the process.

3.1 Ideation

In the ideation phase, we mainly utilized the method Brainwriting, where participants write down ideas related to a chosen theme, individually and silently for a predetermined time [11]. When the time is out, the papers are passed to the next person who then adds to and modifies the concept with their own ideas before passing it along again. It is more common to use the 6-3-5 brainstorming technique, involving six people, three ideas and five minutes per paper. However, we considered it to be sufficient with one idea and one minute per paper as it might otherwise become overwhelming.

Brainwriting is a powerful ideation tool that can be applied in various situations but is commonly used in early stages of concept development as it is an effective way to generate a large range of ideas in a short time [5]. The reasons behind the choice of this particular ideation method were manifold. It ensures that all can contribute with ideas without feeling anxious to take up too much space and the time pressure lowers the bar of what level of refinement is expected. Furthermore the ideas that come out of this process are usually diverse and unexpected and reading them is often a fun activity that promotes a good atmosphere in the group. Brainwriting also ensures that all members feel like they have contributed rather than it appearing to be one person's idea [4]. This

both promotes engagement from all members and makes it easier to dismiss concepts without it feeling personal, since no one's individual idea is singled out or dismissed directly.

3.2 Defining scope

To ensure smooth development and maximize our chances of creating an, in our opinion, adequately polished final product, we spent the first two weeks discussing the scope. The results were: a clear idea of the game's atmosphere, concrete narrative themes we wanted to explore, pixel-art heavy art style with hand-drawn portraits, dialogue driven gameplay with small additional interaction mechanics, and a very intentional beginning, middle and end. The scope was also largely defined by what we were confident we could create within the time-frame. This effectively acted as our project's design pillars and, through diligently kept notes, helped us align on project direction throughout development.

Once we had a common understanding of our game's design pillars and the scope in broad terms, we held an initial backlog creation meeting, where we all collectively acted as "Product Owner". The result was a long list of tasks that we believed needed to be completed before the project could be considered finished. The idea here was not to comprehensively list every single future task, as that would be not only infeasible, but also unhelpful. Instead we wrote down and divided the tasks we knew had to be completed. This helped us gain some understanding of just how quickly a discussed feature balloons into hundreds of individual tasks, while also ensuring that the most important game features were part of the backlog from the start. These features were included both large "Planning" tasks requiring further exploration, and concrete development related tasks like implementing player movement. We then held our first sprint planning meeting, using the newly created backlog to get started. Even though not yet concrete and directly implementable, we found the "Planning" tasks to be incredibly helpful as they allowed us to prioritize exploration and appoint a responsible person.

Due to our project's iterative and playtest-driven development, it was necessary to continually reevaluate the scope. This approach was internally referred to as "MoSCoW Light". Instead of, as in regular MoSCoW, laboriously adding "Must Have", "Should Have", "Could Have" and "Won't Have" labels to each tasks in the backlog, and reassess each task every week, we instead discussed each relevant task in terms of "Must Have", "Should Have" or "Could Have" during sprint planning. This on-the-fly priority assessment made choosing tasks more collaborative and efficient, while still allowing us to prioritize "Must Have" tasks over "Should Have" or "Could Have" tasks. This technique is definitely not guaranteed to work for every team, but our general agreement over project direction and nicely overlapping areas of expertise made it a great fit for us. We also would not necessarily recommend this technique for projects with a larger team, of larger scope or over a bigger time frame, as those decidedly require more structural planning.

3.3 Iterative development

We used an iterative development process as prescribed by the agile development framework. Our method was similar to SCRUM [8], but lighter in some key ways. Our sprints were short, lasting only

one week, and we did not perform any daily standups. Instead we relied on frequent online discussions to share new developments and discuss roadblocks. To keep track of tasks, work-in-progress and our backlog, we used Trello. The tool allowed us to define four task columns in ascending order of completeness: "Backlog", "TODO (this week)", "In Review", and "Done!". Each week we would fill the "TODO (this week)" column with low dependency tasks from the "Backlog" to be completed until the end of the sprint. As the tasks were completed throughout the week, they would be moved to "In Review". Tasks were divided among us through discussion, taking expertise, interest, and workload fairness into account. At the end of each sprint, which we chose to be the course-provided Thursday timeslot, we would each present what we had accomplished that sprint and discuss any potentially remaining roadblocks. This was a great way to ensure that everybody had the same understanding of the project and its direction. We would then move all completed tasks from "In Review" to "Done!" and immediately start the next sprint planning meeting.

We took advantage of the course-provided playtesting sessions whenever we had something new to show or test. Playtesting provided us with invaluable feedback regarding the game systems and through identifying the user needs helped us make informed design decisions. During each sprint planning meeting we discussed the feedback we had received that week, and allowed it to guide the direction of the project going forward. An example of this was how the first time we playtested our movement system, the problems and quirks of which we had discussed internally at length and were ready to rework completely, no playtester found any issues with it and we decided to leave it as it was and instead focus on more pressing matters. Some weeks we opted to use the course-provided playtesting slots to work on the project itself, especially if the state of the playable prototype had not changed significantly enough from last week, or if we were currently in the middle of a big change that had not yet materialized into something testable.

4 Game design and development

Here we will go over what design decisions have been made during the development process. Demonstrating why some choices were made, like the inclusion of extra game mechanics, the choice for a specific color palette, the reasoning for some story beats, and what tools were chosen to best achieve our set goals.

4.1 Game mechanics

Initially, our core game mechanics comprised a dialogue system with multiple choices, a 2D platformer movement system, and an interaction system. In the final product the dialogue system was expanded to support calling commands like the "performHug" event where the player hugs an NPC. It also included a statistics system to track the players choices.

In addition to this, a few smaller mechanics were added. One prominent example is how, if the player jumps off the island, they are shown falling out of the world and then seamlessly being teleported and falling back onto the island. This feature was added to enhance the mystical void-like nature of the space. Another mechanic that was added was how the sprites in the background move with the camera in a parallax effect, creating the illusion of depth.

Furthermore explosions are shown in the background to symbolize the spawning of new spirits on other islands, incorporating key narrative beats into the world itself. Lastly, a pause menu and a main menu to make the game more finished and polished.

4.2 Art Direction

The atmosphere of the game was an important factor in communicating the theme of cozy dystopia. In order to keep a uniform and consistent art direction, a color palette was chosen early on. The palette was chosen to reflect an ethereal, unearthly space. For background colors, shades of dark red/purple/green were chosen to contrast the brighter colored interactive elements to incentivize the player to act.



Figure 1: Level design, player character and two NPCs



Figure 2: dialogue UI and NPC portraits

Colors were also used to communicate belonging and significance, see Figure 1. The NPCs, also referred to as spirits, and their spawning animation were light blue. This way the counter on the island with the same blue color signified its connection to the amount of processed spirits.

The player character was yellow to be distinct from the rest of the spirits, however, it was drawn with a similar transparency as the other spirits. The purple center of the staff matches the candles, hinting at their connection, see Figure 1.

Only two elements in the game were white; the hooks and part of the portraits see Figure 2, 3. Emphasizing the significance of each individual story and their fate. The portraits were drawn to



Figure 3: The Devourer at the end scene of the game

reflect the NPCs personality and history, and the contrasting art style between the portraits and the level design in pixel art was chosen to add depth to the interactions. Hinting that everything is not what it seems, as the cozy exterior is hiding a different reality. The contrasting portraits were connected to the blue NPC through using a blue, pixel art border. And the player character's highlighted choices were in the same yellow color as the character. In the same way as the portraits, The Devourer, the entity encompassing the game setting and devouring the player (and all NPCs) in the final scene, was drawn in a different art style, see Figure 3. Intending to evoke an emotional reaction as the player views the otherworldly entity encompassing the players entire known pixel-art reality they have grown comfortable in.

Pixel art was chosen as an art style to create something familiar that felt like a finished product. It also facilitated making the art appear coherent regardless of whether different people created different elements. The combination of a limited color palette and a pixel art style resulted in a cozy tribute to the limitations of retro hardware.

4.3 Narrative

The story of the game went through multiple shifts in how it was presented, although the central idea of the game, helping spirits before the afterlife, remained the same. At first the game was intended to be portrayed through the lens of a bureaucratic office setting, but it later shifted into a more ethereal void, strewn about with islands. At its core the story is made up of a bunch of smaller stories told by new arriving spirits. This allowed us to easily scale the amount of dialogue by simply adding or removing individual spirits. We decided on seven spirits, which we thought was enough to get the player invested in the larger narrative without boring them. A list of all spirits for future references:

- *Clumsy Spirit* - introspective electrician wanting to make a change.
- *Angry Spirit* - raging hothead in disbelief of his death.
- *Sad Spirit* - timid mother who misses their child.
- *Old Spirit* - devout christian that feels entitled to a great afterlife.
- *Famous Spirit* - extroverted musician heartbroken over her puzzling demise.
- *Depressed Spirit* - melancholic person who ended their life.

- *Disaster Spirit* - loving husband that died in a world ending event.

A floating island level design gave us an opportunity to world-build by representing each island as a different kind of death. The branch which the player is responsible for is the branch of *The Unfortunates*, taking care of the people who die the most pointless and hapless deaths. We also used the level to imply how long the player has been there by etching the number of spirits they've helped on the rock below. Slightly above the island, hooks hang above each spirit awaiting the spirit's final judgment. Once the player makes that choice, one of the previously dangling hooks comes down and brings the spirit up to their ensuing fate. As mentioned in the Game mechanics section, jumping off the island returns the player back to the same island, illustrating that there is no escape.

Feedback from the playtesting sessions inspired us to provide the user with a larger sense of agency over the story. To achieve this we implemented dialogue choices consisting of minor branches that merged back into the main storyline later as well as inconsequential choices that result in the same response. Having multiple choices allowed us to present more information about the main characters personality and letting the player shape their character in some small ways. For that reason, all individual interactions were written to offer different perspectives and reactions to how a person might face their death, giving the player a chance to react and build their own character.

In the end, the player themselves get hooked and brought up to the entity watching over all of the islands. They get devoured, assumingly like the rest of the souls, implying that none of the choices the player made when reincarnating the souls actually had any impact. Our goal with the overarching narrative was to instill into the player a sense of pensiveness and make them reflect on the meaning of choice, death and an afterlife.

4.4 Technical specifications and tools

The game was made in the Unity game engine, with C# as the programming language. For animations, we used Unity's built-in animation and animator components, as well as LeanTween. The dialogue system tool was built by us, using Unity's GraphView packages. We used JSON format data files for storing and managing the statistical data for each player. Sprites were created in LibreSprite, Affinity, Aseprite and Clip Studio Paint. Sound effects were made using bfxr.net, or retrieved from freesound.org with the CC0 license, and edited in Audacity. We used Git for version control and GitHub to host the repository. Fonts were acquired from dafont.com. We made builds for the game on both Windows and Mac. We used Discord for online discussions.

5 Playtesting and evaluation

User testing is an integral part of any design process as it gives insight into how the user perceives and interacts with a product and can provide new perspectives. The feedback derived from the testing sessions has been integral in informing design decisions and ensuring that the game satisfies usability concerns.

5.1 Playtesting methodology

Throughout the development of the game, we have performed repeated user testings and evaluations. The initial testing sessions were formative, qualitative user studies that combined a concurrent think aloud protocol with a semi-structured interview afterwards. This structure was used to allow the participant to talk freely while staying on topic and allowing the interviewer to ask follow-up questions[9]. However, in later testings the interviews were less structured as we were satisfied with the feedback for most of our initial questions and instead sought more specific advice from experienced game developers. The test subject mainly consisted of people involved with the course such as other students and teachers assistants as well as acquaintances. Apart from the testing sessions described here, a final study was also conducted at the exhibition, described in section 7. Final Evaluation.

5.2 Results and Takeaways

The feedback derived from the testing sessions has been integral in informing design decisions and ensuring that the game satisfies usability concerns. The insights contributed to improving the game's *engagement, immersion, and potential for reflection*. The main areas we were interested in evaluating were: *understanding and clarity; theme and narrative; overall experience*.

5.2.1 Understanding and clarity. An initial concern with the game was that users would not understand what to do or how to do it unless first being provided with an explanation. However, from the user testing sessions it became clear that the participants quickly grasped the concept, understood which keys to use and recognized what elements could be interacted with. They also noticed and understood the functionality of the counter which we thought may be unclear. This discovery allowed us to move onto more pressing matters while maintaining the element of organic discovery which we preferred, rather than creating a formal introduction.

During the initial playtestings, the visible, hanging hooks were perceived to be a programming error. This feedback led us to make them sway in the air, making their visibility appear intentional and adding to the ambiance of the scene.

5.2.2 Theme and narrative. As the game is story-driven and emphasizes reflection from the player, understanding the users engagement with the story was highly prioritized. From the playtesting we saw that the users developed emotional connections with the spirits. Specifically they stated to feel compassion with the sad spirit and were amused by the conversations with the old spirit. See chapter 4.4 for a comprehensive list of all spirits and their description. They also expressed that they enjoyed the variation between characters as well as discovering clues about the player character and the afterlife setting through the dialogue.

This feedback was then used when writing the rest of the conversations with the other characters by isolating what users appreciated most in their interactions with the spirits. Users also stated that length of the conversations were appropriate. They were long enough to understand and connect with the characters yet short enough to keep the players invested in the dialogue throughout the conversation. While most players felt they were offered suitable

dialogue options, some expressed a desire for additional choices to enhance their sense of agency and immersion in the game.

5.2.3 Overall experience. We were also interested in how players interpreted the game's message and what they thought of the experience as a whole. We were positively surprised to find that the users, although often playing in a lit classroom and being observed, reported feeling submerged in the game and reflected on the core themes we intended to convey.

At the same time, we also received valuable feedback on how to make the experience more impactful. For example we were advised to add more downtime in between different sequences to give the player more time to reflect rather than instantly moving on to the next task. Users also expressed that they wanted more feedback from their choices such as being able to compare their choices to the "right answers", even though there are none, and being able to see the NPCs turn into the chosen animals. Another interesting point of feedback was to break the formula by adding small tasks and events that interrupts the reading and keep the game from feeling too predictable. Although some elements of this nature had already been considered and partly implemented, this feedback further inspired us to include more unique events.

6 Additions and changes

In this section the additions and changes made after playtesting will be detailed as well as steps taken to improve *game feel* and breaking of the game's formula.

6.1 Changes and design decisions

Making a cozy game, mechanics found in casual and relaxing games were incorporated here. Then, the mechanics of the game are easy to understand, and the player is not required to have any demanding set of skills to play the game. Since it's a story game, the focus was given to simple controls found in casual games and the game's aesthetics rather than complicated mechanics as Wäppling describes in their analysis of casual games [12].

As mentioned in section 5. Playtesting, the playtest sessions, served as a constructive evaluative tool during the whole development and design process, providing the team with meaningful insights on how to improve the player experience. One main feature added after the first playtesting was the statistics system at the end of the game, displaying the player's choices in comparison to previous players' choices proved to be a creative source for retrospect and game interpretations upon finishing the game.

The implementation of the statistics came from the identified user need to make the reincarnation choices feel less irrelevant, as they were looking for a purpose with them. Since the meaninglessness of the choices is a core aspect of the game, the statistics for comparison were added to provide meaning without disrupting the story. Another reason for adding the statistics blocks was that even though the players' choices did not make any difference in the outcome, they wanted to review their options. The statistics system allowed the player to compare their options with each other by displaying the different results of previous playthroughs, making the player feel a sense of belonging [12] that matched the cozy theme effectively.

Moving on to the second playtesting session, one of the most important outcomes of the second playtesting session was the need to break the formula for talking to spirits in a deliberate sequence without any other events. For that reason, from the second playtesting session onwards, more focus was given to introducing some special events in between and during dialogue that would surprise the player, breaking the formula of the game. See subsection 6.3 Breaking the formula.

Music played a very important role in making the game feel more immersive, and together with the sound effects, the players in the end were able to dive into the game more easily. The process of music design had different phases, with the team deciding upon the feeling the music was generating. At first, it had some adventurous elements that the team and other external reviewers found these not that fitting for the game's aesthetic. After some iterations, it was decided to move towards a more ethereal, slow-paced music piece, removing some of the adventurous elements from before, making it more appropriate and matching the ambient atmosphere.

Together with the music, the sound effects additions made a difference for the players' feelings and involvement in the game, something that a lot of people requested during the playtesting sessions and project reviews at the time. The team's direction here was to add details to the level designs' visual elements. For example, by including sound effects as the player walked on the grass, or making the grass sway in the wind as they passed. Adding big "spawning" animations to the spirits arriving, making sure they can be seen no matter where the player is on the island, and together with sound effects, made the visual details come to life.

Several animations were added after the playtesting sessions, making the game feel more alive. For instance, the hook swaying animations made the hooks move in a left-right direction, making them feel like they are hanging from something. Another was the UI overhaul of the game, following the colors and aesthetics of the rest of the graphics. Moreover, after several iterations, The Devourer was implemented, where the carefully drawn frames for the hands and mouth make the final scene look smoother and purposeful. These small but important details gave the game a more polished identity.

Lastly, considerable changes were made during the development process regarding platforming-related features, with attention given to ensure that the controls felt fluid and responsive when executing the movement actions. For instance, having the jump be more ethereal and floatier than sharp and quick, as a more suitable and atmospheric to the game's theme dynamic.

6.2 Game feel

In the book *Game feel*, the author Steve Swink writes that *game feel* consists of three building blocks: Real-Time Control, Simulated Space and Polish [10]. The responsive but floaty movement of the player character was our way of implementing the Real-Time Control building block to fit the game's ethereal theme. The Simulated Space building block was implemented through careful placement of the platforms and the ability to drop through a platform for easy navigation of the world.

While these building blocks are important, most of the *game feel* in *The Unfortunates* comes from the third building block: Polish. Swink writes "Polish refers to any effect that artificially enhances interaction without changing the underlying simulation" and continues with examples of use of sound effects, animations and particles. The platforms in *The Unfortunates* is a great example of *game feel* from Polish. When landing on a platform, three things happen: a sound of rustling leaves is played, simultaneously a part of the platform sprite moves down for a split second and finally three leaves fall from the platform with slightly different delay, gently descending towards the ground. This gives the player an instant and impactful feeling of landing, both visual and auditory. In addition, the falling leaves gives the player a remaining feeling of having interacted with the world.

6.3 Breaking the formula

As described in section 5.2.3, it became apparent through playtesting that players enjoyed, and remembered most fondly, the moments in the narrative where something unexpected or novel happened. Those moments, like allowing the player to lie to a spirit during dialogue, greatly enhanced both world building and character development. We decided to capitalize further on this concept of "breaking the formula" as one playtester neatly put it, by introducing a simple mechanic where a command can be called from the dialogue system. This allowed us to add the "performHug" event where the player can hug a distraught spirit, and the "performJump" event where the player encourages a pensive spirit to jump off the island, only for them to fall back from the top of the screen, just like what happens if the player jumps. These events were relatively quick to implement but enhanced the player's sense of possibility immensely.

Another break-the-formula moment that we had planned from the start was how, towards the end of the game, a huge number of explosions (each denoting a newly diseased person appearing in the afterlife) would start going off in the background, signaling some kind of truly apocalyptic event on earth. From playtesting feedback we made this apocalyptic event more impactful in two key ways: by completely stopping all explosions in the background afterwards, we could imply that literally everyone on Earth was dead, and by making the event extinguish all the candles on the island, we could add some environmental interaction where the player must relight them all before talking to the final spirit who refuses to speak to the player character in the dark. This cemented the apocalyptic event as a unique and important story beat, both narratively and mechanically.

7 Final Evaluation

During the exposition each participant who tested the game [n=31] was asked to complete a survey after completion.

When reflecting on what emotions were experienced, the most common ones were; *sadness*, *intrigue*, *curiosity*, *irritation/annoyance*, *empathy/helpfulness*. One person described feeling a "mix of all human emotions" which can be seen in several responses. As one player described their emotions as "pleasure, judgmental, irritated, sympathy, annoyance, helpfulness" and another "Unease, frustration, helplessness, anomie, anxiety".

The latter participant described the game as "A philosophical platformer which has a really interesting aesthetic and may lead to existential dread." and reflected on the game's meaning as "That we should all be nihilists as there is no point to anything, we will all die, and we have no control over our eternal fate." with the added commentary that they really liked the game.

Many descriptions referred to the game as a philosophical experience, when asked to describe the game to a friend, some answers were: "Like a Russian deconstructionist novel in game form"; "Introspective and personal"; "It's a thoughtful game. It will make you think about destiny and death". Many participants referred to the game as *narrative driven*, *cozy*, *dark*, *mysterious*, and *dystopian*. Games mentioned in comparisons were: *Disco Elysium* [13], *Spiritarer* [3] and *Wayfarer* [2].

When asked if there was anything they wanted to do that the game wouldn't let them a majority, 54.8%, answered no or refrained from answering. One of these respondents wrote: "No, I think the game was great and very polished for the small experience it was, I wouldn't change anything. The writing was really good, I didn't get keyholed into a black and white answer, they often had a bit of nuance and interpretation to them".

The other answers can be grouped into three groups: *exposition*, *exploration and refinement*. Most comments surrounded the exposition and world-building, where players wanted to be able to find out more about the player character through more dialogue options, as well as finding out the truth about the space they were in. For exploration some wanted a bigger level, more space to explore and more spirits to talk to. Refinement requests were one platform that could not be reached from ground level, being given more dialogue options and more animals to choose from for the reincarnation, for example a condemning reincarnation e.g. "vile cockroach". One person asked to know more about the spirits wishes, more specifically what animals the people wanted to be reincarnated as.

When rating their immersion the mean was 4.4 on a scale of 1-5, where 1 was *not immersed at all, distracted and bored* and 5 was *very immersed, forgot time and space*. Since the exposition playtesting was in a well lit, loud, public space the result was higher than expected.

8 Discussion

This section considers the players' feelings and ideas during the exhibition, providing considerations regarding the valuable feedback and criticism of the game.

8.1 Player Experience

8.1.1 Statistics: Player choices. As mentioned in the previous chapter, during the exposition, the participants discussed their own interpretations of the meaning behind the game, as well as their choices for the spirits. These were based on the players' subjective judgment of the stories. Figure 4 illustrates the summary of the decisions the players made for each of the spirits during the reincarnation choice. A total of forty-two [n=42] choices were stored for each Spirit, and there were four options to choose from as the reincarnation animals.

The results revealed some interesting behavioral insights from the players. For example, the majority choose the "brave wolf" for

the Clumsy Spirit, and the main reason for that was the need to fulfill someone's wishes since the Clumsy Spirit talks about being part of a pack, and how they would like not to be alone in the next one. For that reason, more than 60% of the participants decided to grant the spirit's wish by reincarnating it into a "brave wolf", which is considered a social animal. Similarly, the Sad Spirit was mainly reincarnated as birds, following the spirits' wishes to fly in the next life. With both "silent owl" and "wise crow" being selected most frequently.

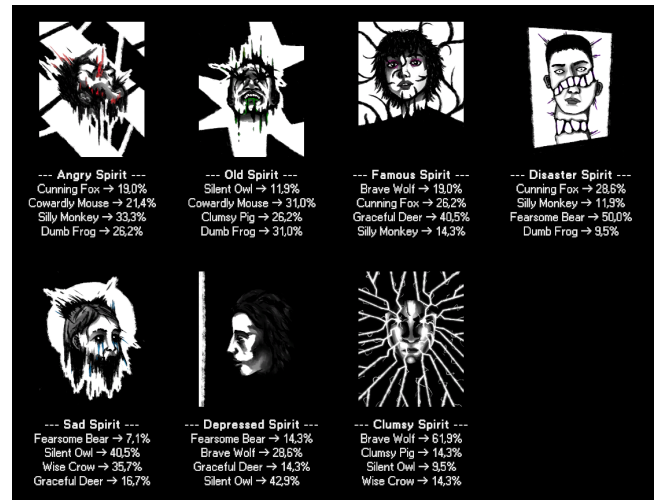


Figure 4: Final statistics of 42 replies during the exhibition

8.1.2 Impressions: Player choices. Since the players judge the spirits based on the relationship they form during the short dialogue, first impressions were important. One participant, for example, decided to choose the harshest possible selections even though later they discussed some of them not being as negative as they had thought. This was understood as an insufficient way to express how they felt about the spirits, with some expressing that there were not many choices to choose from, and some were not fully aligned with their judgment. For example, a participant mentioned, "The Sad Spirit did not really have any bad options, so you are forced to decide a favorable fate for them."

Some spirits had a more even distribution between choices, most notably the Angry Spirit, Famous Spirit and the Old Spirit, see Figure 4. Some people commented that "Silly Monkey", for example, was not intended by them as a form of punishment, even though the Spirit's reaction might indicate that they saw it as one. In the same way, one participant commented that they felt like being a "Dumb Frog" was a blissful choice rather than a condemning one. Meaning that the 'favourable fate' would depend on the individual player's interpretation of both the reincarnation choices as well as their impression of the NPC. When these two were aligned between players, the results were more united.

Most of the participants were content with their choices, but at the same time, they felt a lack of control when encountering the last sequence, where it is revealed that the players' choices ultimately carried no agency in the predetermined fate. It was designed to make the users reflect on free will and nihilism in an impactful and

unexpected way. For instance, one mentioned that they became less compassionate about their choices after seeing the final scene, while another one said, “The game felt a lot more complete in worldbuilding, like the story coming together”. Furthermore, to leave the players with some positive perspectives and takeaways, we tried balancing the fatalism by including elements of compassion and positive player agency, such as the performHug event.

To further provide the users with some distance to the heavy subjects treated in the game, a pixelated rather than a realistic artstyle was employed. This aimed to convey that the game is merely a theoretical concept and does not claim to portray the truth.

8.1.3 Future Work. Playtesters had very insightful suggestions on how to incorporate more elements into the reincarnation options, such as including all the available animals in the final dialogue during the reincarnation phase to choose from, or another one mentioned splitting up the animals and the adjectives accompanying them and let the players decide a combination of both to provide more flexibility and player agency in expressing a more accurate conclusion for the spirits’ evaluation. However, even though the team considered there to be interesting additions and modifications, they were not implemented since it would have broadened our scope.

As mentioned in Chapter 7. Final Evaluations: The players experienced a wide spectrum of emotions during gameplay. One of the more common emotions reported was *irritation/annoyance*. When comparing the individual responses from those participants, there are no hints of irritation or annoyance toward game mechanics, more likely these were feelings toward some of the characters or the reveal at the end of the game. One participant who described feeling “compassion, sadness, irritation” also wrote that the game was “amazing! would recommend”. As some characters are written to be “annoying” in order to instigate a moral dilemma of however the player has the right to judge or condemn a spirit to a subjectively bad afterlife due to the players negative feelings toward them. However, since there was no interview where probing could be implemented to understand the playtesters intention it would require further study to conclude what parts of the game evoked feelings of *annoyance* and *irritation*.

Much of the feedback for improvement on the game described in Chapter 7 was beyond the scope of the game. Improvements such as a bigger game level, more stories, and so forth were discussed and dismissed during development. However, in potential future development the feedback would prove valuable.

8.2 Ethical considerations

8.2.1 Development Process. When conducting user tests, we adhered to ethical guidelines for user experience research, prioritizing participant well-being and informed consent [7]. Participants were informed beforehand that their participation was voluntary and that the data collected would be anonymized and solely used for the development of the game and for academic reporting. We also discussed the experience with the players afterward to ensure that they were not experiencing any strong feelings of distress or unease regarding the heavy topics of the game.

8.2.2 Theme and message. The aim of the game has been to challenge the players to reflect on existential and philosophical topics regarding life and death, free will and fate, but not to attack or discredit any existing beliefs. Our intention and ethical responsibility have been to treat these subjects with respect and to evoke reflection rather than affliction, as the theme of the afterlife can be a controversial and sensitive subject.

To create religious and cultural neutrality, we decided to create our own fictional scene and story. By not overdoing obvious references to established religions, we aimed to avoid controversy while also ensuring that the narrative can be equally relatable to players with different preconceived notions. With that said, elements of rebirth and its dependence on actions in the previous life can be found in different forms can be found in several religions and beliefs, most prominently in Indian religions and philosophy [1]. Furthermore, clear associations can be seen between one of the characters and the Christian faith. The latter characters’ dialogue was designed to prompt the users to reflect on their own faith.

9 Conclusion

Considering the feedback from the final evaluation, we believe that the creation of *The Unfortunates* accomplishes the goal of creating a finished, polished game that engages players a thought-provoking experience. The constructive criticism was mostly about players wanting more in terms of exposition and exploration. While we agree with this feedback, having more content than what is currently in the game would have made it more difficult to reach the goal of making a game that feels finished.

The reported immersion rate could be interpreted as the game being polished enough to be considered a full, finished game. In addition to this, most respondents in the survey felt like the game allowed them to do everything they wanted with comments highlighting how the game felt polished. The comments referring to the game as being a “philosophical experience” shows that *The Unfortunates* prompted players to think seriously about the game’s theme.

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